

Unruly Marshes: Unveiling Paradoxes of Turbid Restoration Projects in Wet Environments. The case of the Venice Lagoon

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Extended Abstract

This dissertation arises from a personal, disciplinary, and political necessity to rethink how ecological restoration is conceived and practised, particularly in wet environments where ambiguity, instability, and layered histories are the rule rather than the exception. Set in the hybrid and transitional landscape of the Venice Lagoon, the research engages with restoration projects not to propose better solutions, but to unpack their limitations, contradictions, and embedded assumptions. The point of departure is the realisation that many of these projects, although well-intended and scientifically informed, fail to accommodate the fluid, relational, and socio-ecologically entangled character of the places they aim to ‘fix.’

The concept of turbidity—borrowed from both physical and metaphorical registers—serves as a lens to make sense of this condition. It is a quality of water, but also of vision; a refusal of clarity, purity, and technical certainty. By tracing turbidity across different scales and practices, the thesis questions the legacy of modernist, dualistic frameworks underpinning many restorative efforts: nature versus culture, land versus water, human versus non-human. These binaries do not hold in the Lagoon, nor do they serve the landscapes shaped by sediment, tide, wind, and memory.

The *barene*, the brackish marshes occupying the in-between zones of the Lagoon, become the focal point of this inquiry. Their partial submersion, ecological fragility, and spatial

marginality render them a powerful medium through which to interrogate dominant restoration logics. Far from being passive recipients of design, the *barene* are treated here as agents—as terrains of resistance, memory, and transformation. Through them, the thesis suggests that restoration is not a neutral technical act, but a situated, contested practice entangled in cultural imaginaries, institutional frameworks, and spatial politics.

Methodologically, the research unfolds through a combination of critical theory, archival and counter-archival work, field-based investigations, and collaborations with local practitioners, artists, scientists, and activists. Walking, mapping, narrating, listening, and convening are all employed not only as means of knowledge production but as ways of inhabiting and responding to the Lagoon. The structure of the dissertation reflects this layered approach, progressing through spatial, temporal, operational, and conceptual dimensions, each unravelled and reassembled through a feminist and eco-systemic lens.

Rather than offering prescriptive solutions, the thesis advocates for a practice of landscape architecture that is reflexive, situated, and responsive to the uncertain, turbid realities of wetland environments. It asks what it might mean to design not in control of nature, but with it—without erasing conflict, contradiction, or opacity. In doing so, it aspires to open space for alternative, more-than-human narratives and for landscape design practices that are deeply attuned to both ecological processes and socio-cultural intricacies.